

Chapter 20: When It Becomes Real

Jenny stopped counting the days.

Not because she forgot.

But because it stopped making sense.

Austin came.

He stayed.

He left.

And came back again.

Like it was no longer a decision.

Just a fact.

Table seven was no longer just a table.

It had become a constant.

Something she adjusted her day around without meaning to.

Something she noticed even when she wasn't looking.

That was the part she hated most.

Because it meant he had changed her routine.

Without asking.

Without forcing.

Just by existing inside it long enough.

"Jenny."

Bao's voice pulled her back.

"Order up."

"I know," she said quickly.

But she didn't move immediately.

Her eyes flicked—again—toward table seven.

Austin was already there.

Waiting.

As always.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"Stop doing that," she muttered under her breath.

Bao smirked.

"Stop doing what?"

"Nothing."

"You were talking to him in your head again."

"I wasn't."

Bao leaned closer.

"You always check him first now."

Jenny froze.

"I don't."

"You do."

"I don't."

Bao raised his eyebrows.

"You're doing it right now."

Jenny turned away fast.

Too fast.

"Shut up."

But Bao just laughed.

Because he was right.

And she knew it.

When she finally approached Austin's table, he looked up immediately.

Like he had been waiting for that exact second.

Jenny forced her expression neutral.

"Same as usual?"

"Yes."

No hesitation.

No small talk.

But today...

He didn't look away after answering.

He kept looking at her.

Jenny noticed.

Of course she did.

She placed the order down.

"You're staring."

"I'm looking."

"Same thing."

"No," he said calmly. "It's not."

A pause.

Jenny sighed.

"You're in a mood today."

"I'm not."

"You are."

Austin leaned back slightly.

"I've been thinking."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Dangerous habit for you."

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

But it faded quickly.

"I don't want this to stay undefined," he said.

Jenny blinked.

"...Defined?"

"Yes."

"That sounds like a business problem."

"It's worse than that."

Jenny frowned.

"What is it then?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said quietly,

"It's you."

That landed too directly.

Too simply.

Jenny's chest tightened slightly.

"That's not an answer," she said.

"It is for me."

Silence.

The restaurant noise felt distant again.

Jenny forced herself to breathe normally.

"You're making this sound bigger than it is."

"I'm not."

"Yes, you are."

"I'm making it honest."

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

But this time...

Austin didn't let the silence drift too long.

"I don't want to guess anymore," he said.

Jenny frowned slightly.

"Guess what?"

"If you feel the same."

That made her freeze.

The question wasn't loud.

Wasn't demanding.

It was worse.

It was patient.

Jenny's hands tightened slightly at her sides.

"You shouldn't ask that."

"Why?"

"Because it changes things."

"They already changed."

Jenny shook her head.

"No. You changed them."

Austin studied her face.

Then said quietly,

"I know."

That honesty again.

Always there.

Always steady.

Jenny felt something inside her shift uncomfortably.

Like something she had been holding too tightly for too long.

She stepped back slightly.

"I need to work."

Austin didn't stop her.

But he said softly,

"I'm not leaving without an answer anymore."

Jenny stopped.

Slowly turned back.

"...That sounds like a threat."

"It's not."

"Then what is it?"

A pause.

Then—

"A decision."

Jenny stared at him.

For a moment, she didn't speak.

Didn't move.

Didn't breathe properly.

Because something about the way he said it...

Made it real.

Not playful.

Not confusing.

Real.

Behind them, Bao whispered:

"Oh... this is it."

Jenny shot him a look.

He immediately looked away.

But she barely registered it.

Because Austin was still looking at her.

Waiting.

Not pushing.

Just waiting.

And for the first time...

Jenny realized she couldn't just walk away from this anymore.

Not cleanly.

Not easily.

Not without answering something she had been avoiding since the beginning.